

AI Datacentres in Ontario - Ontarians Against Corruption

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Source Content

Artificial intelligence (AI) datacentres are being built at an unprecedented pace, but the environmental and community impacts are being overlooked in the rush to expand. These massive facilities require enormous amounts of electricity to power thousands of servers and millions of litres of water to keep them cool. This is placing increasing pressure on local power grids, water supplies, and surrounding communities. Despite their scale, many AI datacentre projects can move forward without comprehensive environmental impact assessments or meaningful public consultation. Existing planning and zoning processes often contain loopholes that allow projects to be approved with limited scrutiny, while regulations have failed to keep pace with the rapid growth of AI infrastructure. Communities are frequently left asking who benefits, who bears the costs, and why there are so few safeguards in place. At the same time, Canada's push to become a global AI leader through initiatives like Mark Carney's "AI for All" has focused on accelerating AI adoption and investment, but far less attention has been given to protecting natural resources, ensuring transparency, or establishing strong national standards for water use, energy consumption, emissions, and community consultation. AI innovation should not come at the expense of our environment or our communities. Before more AI data centres are approved, governments must close regulatory loopholes, require independent environmental assessments, ensure meaningful public consultation, and hold developers accountable for the true environmental and social costs of these projects. Supporters of AI Datacentres say that they are beneficial because they create a number of construction jobs, significant tax revenue for local governments, and reduced reliance on residential property taxes, which may for lower taxes on households.